3 The Story of Mulan

Supplementary

This is the classic story of Mulan based on the legend of Hua Mulan. A legend is a story from long ago that is believed to be true, or mostly true.

Many years ago, China was in the middle of a great war. The Emperor said that one man from each Chinese family must leave his family to join the army. Mulan, a teenage girl who lived in a faraway village of China, heard the news when she was outside, washing clothes.

Mulan ran into the house. Her father was sitting in a chair, carving a piece of wood. "Father!" she said. "Did you hear what the Emperor says each family must do?"

"Yes," said her old father, "I heard about it in town. Well, I may as well go pack up." He put down his carving, stood up and walked very slowly to his room.

"Wait!" said Mulan, "Father, you have not been well. If I may say so, why at your age must you keep up with all those young men?"

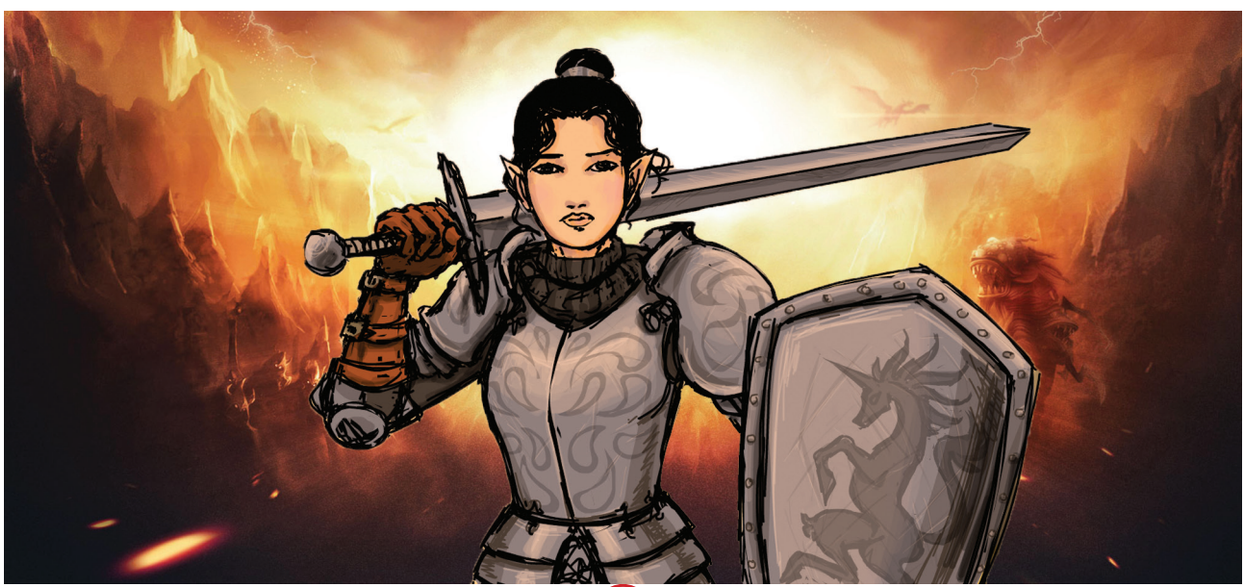
"What else can be done?" said her father. "Your brother is a child. He cannot go."

"Of course that's true," said Mulan. "He is too little. But I have an idea." She poured her father a cup of tea and handed it to him. "Father, have some tea. Please sit for a minute. I will be right back."

"Very well, dear," said the father.

Mulan went into her room. With her sword, she cut off her long, black hair. She put on her father's robe. Going back to her father, Mulan said, "Look at me. I am your son now. I will go in your place. I will do my part for China."

"No, my daughter!" said the old man. "You cannot do this!"



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